

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump called **Iran's** [response](#) to **America's** proposal to end the war “totally unacceptable”. Few details of Iran's reply have been released, but it reportedly prioritised ending hostilities within the region and ensuring safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz. Meanwhile, Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister said the war would not end until Iran relinquished all of its highly enriched uranium, suggesting this might be done by force.

Factory prices in **China** rose by 2.8% year on year in April, the biggest increase since 2022. China's statistics ministry blamed the “rapid rise in international commodity prices” and greater demand in “certain domestic sectors”. The war in Iran has helped end [China's deflationary slide](#) but domestic demand remains sluggish. Consumer prices increased by 1.2%.

China's foreign ministry confirmed [the summit](#) between **Xi Jinping** and **Mr Trump** will go ahead this week. Mr Trump will arrive in China on May 14th. The war caused the leaders' previously scheduled meeting to be postponed. The conflict will be one of many contentious topics under discussion. Last week America imposed sanctions on three Chinese satellite firms for supplying images to Iran.

Alphabet announced plans to issue bonds denominated in **Japanese yen** for the first time, as it seeks to raise more funding for its artificial-intelligence splurge. Google's parent company is hoping to spend \$190bn on [AI infrastructure](#) in 2026. Last week the firm raised nearly \$17bn by issuing euro-denominated and Canadian-dollar bonds.

Ukraine and **Russia** accused one another of breaking a three-day ceasefire. The American-brokered truce began on Saturday. Ukraine said that Russian strikes had killed one person; Russia accused Ukraine of wounding several people in the Kherson region of Ukraine, which it occupies. Earlier Russia's president, **Vladimir Putin**, said that he believed that the war is "coming to an end".

Narendra Modi, India's prime minister, urged citizens to use fuel "sparingly". He asked them to carpool, work from home and reduce non-essential travel abroad. The blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has caused [particular strain in Asia](#), the destination for almost 90% of the oil and gas [that transited the waterway](#) last year. Several countries, including Sri Lanka and the Philippines, have mandated energy-saving policies.

France's prime minister, Sébastien Lecornu, said a citizen flying back to France after sailing on the *MV Hondius* was [showing symptoms](#) of **hantavirus**. Four other French citizens on the specially chartered flight were also quarantined. Six passengers on the cruise ship were confirmed with the disease; three died. Meanwhile British soldiers parachuted onto Tristan da Cunha, a remote British territory, to deal with a suspected case there.

Figure of the day: Almost 2%. The reduction in carbon-dioxide concentration when 60 square centimetres of plants were placed in an office, according to one study. [Do houseplants actually improve air quality?](#)



Photograph: Getty Images

Will Labour get a new leader?

Britain's Labour Party is still reeling from the disastrous local elections of May 7th, when it lost hundreds of seats in its traditional heartlands. Some MPs, though, are past grieving: about 30 Labour lawmakers have publicly called for their leader, [Sir Keir Starmer, to resign](#)—a step he insists he won't take. Dozens more have expressed their discontent without explicitly demanding that the prime minister fall on his sword.

But only one has gone as far as to say she will challenge Sir Keir for the leadership. Catherine West, a backbencher, says she will put her name forward if no cabinet minister steps up by Monday. Ms West is unlikely to garner the necessary 81 nominations from MPs, but she might encourage potential big hitters, including [Andy Burnham](#), the ambitious mayor of Greater Manchester, [Angela Rayner](#), Sir Keir's former deputy, and Wes Streeting, the health minister. Ms West wants to begin collecting nominations ahead of Parliament's opening on Wednesday. By then more MPs may be beyond denial and demanding action.



Photograph: Getty Images

The triple threat to Saudi Aramco

Saudi Aramco, the world's largest oil company, will boast to investors of its resilience on Monday when it expands on its first-quarter results. Analysts had been worried that many shipments would be bottled up by the blockade of the [Strait of Hormuz](#), and that production would be damaged by Iran's attacks on energy infrastructure.

In fact, the colossus defied expectations by posting net profits of \$33.6bn on Sunday, up a quarter year on year, and continuing to pay a large dividend to its government owners. Saudi Aramco used pipelines to reroute exports away from Hormuz and benefited from higher oil prices.

Still, three challenges loom. Iran could inflict new damage on those vital pipelines. And, though Aramco may want to slash its dividend to pay for fixing war-related damage, the Saudi state, which also needs the money, may say no. Finally, as Amin Nasser, the firm's boss, warned, if hostilities continue beyond a few weeks, supply disruptions will persist and the market will not normalise until 2027.

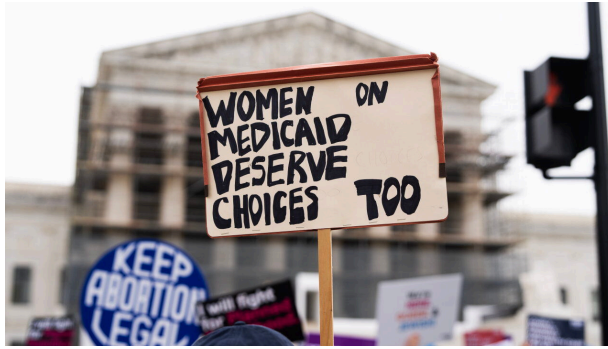


Photograph: Getty Images

Bringing Ukraine's children home

Over 20,000 [Ukrainian kids have been deported](#) from their homes towards Russia and the territories it seized during the full-scale invasion from 2022, according to authorities in Kyiv. On Monday foreign ministers representing Canada, Ukraine and the European Union will meet in Brussels to co-ordinate their efforts to trace, return, and reintegrate the forcibly transferred youngsters.

Russia has long denied that it has carried out a [mass kidnapping scheme](#), which the UN decries as both a crime against humanity and a war crime. The EU has imposed sanctions on over 60 individuals who helped organise the operation, which involves re-education and indoctrination. A coalition of 47 countries and international organisations are taking part in efforts to return the children. So far around 2,000 have been returned home. The fate of many others remains unclear.



Photograph: Getty Images

The state of abortions in America

In the first half of 2025 over a quarter of [abortions in America](#) were provided remotely—many of them in states where the procedure is banned and the women received mifepristone pills by post. That is, in part, why although 17 states have banned or severely limited abortions, more are provided now than they were in 2022. A ban on prescribing mifepristone remotely was put on pause by the Supreme Court earlier this month at the request of abortion-pill manufacturers. An appeals court had blocked provision of the drug through telemedicine.

That pause ends on Monday. Louisiana, which would like the pills only to be available in person, filed its latest arguments to the court on Thursday. If the state's case succeeds, it will upend America's tenuous settlement on abortion. Donald Trump has been relatively mum on the issue, which has contributed to the relative success of the Democrats in the 2022 midterms. Abortion returning to the headlines may make some Republicans quiver—a greater possibility if the ban is upheld.



Photograph: Reuters

France charts a new path in Africa

France has for decades held regular get-togethers with Africa's French-speaking leaders, members of *la francophonie*. On Monday, for the first time, it is co-hosting an Africa summit in an Anglophone country: Kenya. Over two days "Africa Forward" will bring together international political leaders and businesspeople. For William Ruto, Kenya's president, and other African leaders, the emphasis on investment, finance and tech is a welcome opportunity to showcase what the continent has to offer.

For Emmanuel Macron, France's president, the summit is symbolic too. It represents a pivot away from an Africa policy focused on its former colonies and weighed down by historical baggage. Mr Macron wants instead to mark a "renewed partnership". Last year France was forced by hostile military leaders in the Sahel to close its last military base there. Mr Macron is hoping to show that the country is forging diversified alliances by choice, not coercion.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which Renaissance artist had a sideline as a military engineer for Cesare Borgia?

*It's no measure of health to be
well adjusted to a profoundly sick
society.*

Jiddu Krishnamurti